

Love and Ground State

Measure what being together costs you, keep the cost honest, and never confuse a trap for a home.

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Who this is for

You're in a relationship and you can't tell whether you're tired or unhappy. Or you're starting one and want to know what to check before the lease gets signed. Or you left one, and you need a way to understand what you paid that doesn't reduce to "it failed."

This course gives you one framework and makes it carry weight. No scripts, no personality types, no love languages. One set of quantities — where you'd naturally rest, where you actually are, what the gap costs you daily, what going back would cost you once — applied to the highest-stakes shared state most people ever enter.

It is not a course on finding someone. It is a course on what being with someone does to your state, and how to keep that survivable, honest, and chosen. The goal is not detachment. The goal is love that stays chosen — which is the only kind that stays love.

Module 1: Two Ground States

Your ground is not negotiable

You have a ground state. Call it S0: the configuration you settle into when nothing is pulling on you. When you sleep, left alone. How much silence you need in a day. What you cook when it's just you — the pot of beans, the same three meals on rotation, eaten standing up or at a set table. Whether a free Saturday means people or means no people. How much order you need, how much mess you can stand, how much risk feels like life and how much feels like threat. What you believe when you're not performing for anyone.

S0 is not your preferences. Preferences negotiate. S0 is what your system returns to when negotiation stops — the state that costs you nothing to hold. You can live away from it; plenty of people do, for decades. But you cannot relocate it by deciding to. It moves slowly, if at all, and never because someone asked it to.

Most people cannot describe their own S0. They've lived displaced so long they mistake their adaptations for their nature. That's the first piece of work in this course, and nothing after it lands until it's done.

The other person has one too

The person you love has a ground state, and it is exactly as non-negotiable as yours. This sounds obvious. Almost nobody acts like it's true.

In early love, both people present a curated state: flexible, agreeable, suddenly fond of whatever the other one is fond of. This is not deceit, mostly. Infatuation is a state of voluntary displacement — being near someone new pulls you off your ground, and it feels like energy because it is energy. Yours, being spent. Both of you are paying gladly, so neither of you notices that anyone is paying at all.

Then, a year or two in, the other person “changes.” The one who loved your friends starts staying home. The one who was up for anything reverts to the same Sunday, every Sunday. They have not changed. They have returned. You are meeting their S0 for the first time, and they are meeting yours, and the entire question of whether this works is the question of how far apart those two grounds sit.

What fusion actually is

A relationship, operationally, is not a feeling. It is a shared state — call it *S*, *the actual state* — *that two people live in together: one apartment, one schedule, one bed, one set of holidays, one way of speaking when others are in the room. Fusion is not the merging of souls. It is two people agreeing on one S* and each displacing toward it from their own ground.

That reframe does a lot of work. It means compatibility is geometry: the distance between two ground states determines the minimum total displacement any shared state can demand. If your grounds are close, there exists an S^* near both, and living together can be cheap for both of you. If your grounds are far apart, every possible S^* is expensive for someone — the only choice is who pays, or how the bill gets split.

You can build the shared state anywhere. You just have to pay rent on the distance. Both of you. Separately. Every day.

Practice

This week, write your S0 on one page. Concrete only: sleep, food, solitude, money habits, what a free Saturday actually looks like, what you do when no one is watching. Then write the other person’s S0 on a second page, as honestly as you can manage. If you’re not with anyone, write the S0 of the last person you loved.

- Which page was harder to write — yours or theirs — and what does that tell you?
- What exists in your current shared life that appears on neither page?
- When did you last spend a full day at your own ground? What did it feel like?

Module 2: The Three Numbers

xi: how much you changed to be here

Displacement — xi — is the gap between your ground state and the shared one. Not how much you bent at the beginning; beginnings distort everything. How far you are holding yourself away from your own ground right now, on an ordinary Tuesday, with nothing special happening.

Healthy love has small xi for both people. Read that precisely. Not zero — a shared state identical to your solo ground state is just two people in adjacent rooms, and some displacement is the relationship: their family at your table, their sleep schedule brushing against yours, a city you wouldn’t have picked alone. The question is never whether you moved. It’s how far, and whether the move was toward something or merely away from yourself.

There’s an asymmetry to watch for: xi is measured per person. A relationship can be nearly free for one and ruinous for the other, and from the outside — even from inside — it can look like harmony, because the one paying has learned to pay quietly. If you only audit the relationship’s mood, you’ll miss this. Audit the displacement, each of you, separately.

D(xi): rest or vigilance

Displacement is not billed once. You pay it daily — call the daily cost $D(x_i)$ — and it grows with the gap. Small gap, small bill: you surrender the good side of the bed, you watch some shows you'd never pick, you eat dinner an hour earlier than your body wants. Large gap, large bill: you monitor what you say before you say it, you manage their reactions like weather, you perform a self that isn't yours and call the performance "effort," you leave every shared evening slightly more depleted than you entered it.

Here is the cleanest test in this course. After an ordinary evening together — no event, no fight, no occasion — are you more rested or less? Rest is what low D feels like from the inside. Vigilance is what high D feels like. A body that relaxes in someone's presence is reporting a short distance home. A body that stays slightly braced, year after year, is reporting a long one — no matter what the mouth says about how happy you are.

People override this signal for years. The signal does not stop. It just changes form: the irritability, the flatness, the relief you feel — and then feel guilty for feeling — when their trip gets extended a day.

C_return: the door

C_{return} is the one-time cost of going back to your own ground. What leaving would actually cost you — today, itemized. The apartment unwound. The money untangled. The friends who were really theirs. The story your family tells about the two of you, rewritten. The grief, which is the largest line item and the only one you can't schedule.

Most people refuse to know this number. That refusal feels like loyalty. It isn't. Here is the part of this course most worth the price: a low C_{return} is good for the relationship. If leaving is thinkable, then every day you stay is a day you chose. If leaving is unthinkable — if the cost has drifted so high you can't even afford to calculate it — then staying stops being a choice and becomes a condition. And love that is a condition curdles. Not always into cruelty. More often into politeness, the long quiet politeness of two people who no longer ask the question because neither could afford the answer.

You don't keep C_{return} low by keeping one foot out the door. You keep it low by remaining a person: your own friends, your own work, your own ground, intact and visited. The door stays a door. Then walking past it every day means something.

A toy model

As a toy model — illustrative numbers, nothing more — suppose staying displaced in a too-far relationship costs you 3 units a day in vigilance and self-management, and a clean return to your own ground would cost 600 units once: the move, the logistics, the grief. In 200 days, the daily bills exceed the exit. In five years they exceed it many times over, and you've paid them anyway, in installments small enough to ignore.

Now suppose instead the daily cost is 0.3 — a near ground state shared with someone whose ground sits close to yours. The same arithmetic now runs decades before staying costs more than leaving, and meanwhile the relationship is generating rest rather than consuming it. Nothing about commitment changed between these two cases. Only the geometry did.

People run this arithmetic whether or not they admit it. The body keeps the ledger even when the mind refuses to read it.

Practice

For seven evenings, after time together, write one word in your phone: *rested* or *vigilant*. No analysis, no justification, just the word. At the end of the week, count.

- What was the ratio, and did it surprise you?
- On the vigilant evenings, what exactly were you monitoring?
- If a friend showed you their seven words and they matched yours, what would you tell them?

Module 3: Why Love Fails

You chose someone far from your ground

The first failure happens before the relationship does. You chose someone whose ground state sits far from yours, and you did it because distance generates intensity. A person far from your S0 is electric precisely because being near them displaces you — the charge you feel is the gradient itself, your own state being dragged somewhere new. It reads as aliveness. It is, technically, expenditure.

So the spark is not a lie, but it is not information about compatibility either. It is information about voltage. Compatibility is boring to describe — we want the same Saturday, we tire at the same hour, money means roughly the same thing to us — and cheap to live. Incompatibility is thrilling to describe and ruinous to live, because every thrilling difference becomes a daily payment once the shared state has to actually hold both of you.

Nobody warns you that the early intensity and the later exhaustion are the same quantity, experienced at different durations. Big xi feels like passion in month two and like a job in year four. The feeling changed; the distance never did.

You dissolved

The second failure is slower and looks, the entire time, like virtue. You started close. Then, one reasonable concession at a time, you gave away the things your ground state was made of. The morning run went first — schedules. Then the friend who knew you at nineteen — she never clicked with your partner, and the logistics got hard. Then the work that was yours, narrowed to fit a shared life that kept needing more room. Every single trade defensible. No single moment where it went wrong.

The obvious damage is that xi grew: the shared state drifted, and you drifted with it, further and further from your ground. The deeper damage is worse — your S0 itself goes quiet from disuse. Unvisited, it stops being legible even to you. Ask a dissolved person what they'd return to if they returned to themselves, and watch their face: they don't know. And someone who cannot locate their own ground cannot even measure their displacement. They just feel tired everywhere, including alone, and conclude something is wrong with them rather than with the geometry.

Dissolution also silently torches C_return. You can't go home if home has been sold off in pieces. The person who gave up everything to be loved has also, by the same motion, made leaving impossible — which means staying has stopped being a choice, which means the love they bought with all that self is no longer the kind that's chosen. The sacrifice consumes the thing it was made for.

The door rusted shut

The third failure is entanglement: C_return ratcheting upward, click by click, until leaving moves from expensive to unthinkable. The merged accounts. The lease, then the mortgage. The single shared social circle. The identity — everyone you know thinks of you as half of a unit, and so, by now, do you. Sometimes children, who raise the cost of return for real and worthy reasons and are not a failure of anything.

Be precise here, because this is where the framework gets misread. Entanglement itself is not the failure. A life genuinely built together *should* be expensive to unwind — that expense is the mass of something real. The failure is letting the cost climb so far past thinkable that you stop doing the arithmetic at all. The moment you can no longer afford to know what you would choose, you have stopped choosing. And a person in a room with no exit behaves differently than a person in a room with a door: more careful, less honest, slowly resentful. High C_return doesn't just trap you — it raises D too, because vigilance is what no-exit feels like from the inside. The trap makes the days worse, and the worse days make you less able to afford the exit. That spiral, not the entanglement, is the failure.

(This is a framework for thinking, not financial or legal advice — for real decisions about shared money, property, or separation, work with a qualified professional.)

One root

Three failures, one root: arithmetic abandoned. You didn't check the distance before fusing. You didn't watch the displacement grow. You didn't keep the cost of return inside the thinkable. Love doesn't usually die of a blow. It dies of unread ledgers.

Practice

Name your nearest failure mode — chose far, dissolved, or rusted shut — and write one paragraph of honest evidence for it, like a prosecutor who likes you. If you're not in a relationship, write it about your last one.

- Which single concession do you most regret, and what did it actually buy?
- What part of your ground state has gone quietest, and when did you last visit it?
- What would have to be true for the door to be a door again?

Module 4: Maintenance

Returns on a schedule

The maintenance theorem, stated plainly: returning on a schedule beats letting displacement accumulate. Drift compounds; each return has a fixed cost; the optimal frequency balances the fixed cost of returning against the rate of drift. Skip ten small returns and you do not owe ten small payments later — you owe one large one, plus interest, because displacement that sits begins to set.

Everything in this module is that theorem applied three ways: return to each other daily, return to the choice seasonally, return to yourself always.

Presence, daily

Couples do not drift apart in a night. They drift two millimeters a day with no return scheduled — parallel logistics, parallel phones, a shared address and no shared state. The fix is cheap precisely because it's frequent: the fixed cost of a real return to each other, done daily, is about ten minutes. Undistracted, no logistics, no screens. What actually happened in you today — not around you, in you.

Ten minutes sounds too small to matter. That's the theorem talking: small and scheduled beats large and someday. The couples who "need to reconnect" with a big annual trip are paying the accumulated bill, with interest, that ten daily minutes would have kept at zero. Take the trip anyway. But the trip is not the maintenance. The kitchen is.

Revisit the choice

Once a season, alone, ask yourself the forbidden question: *knowing everything I know now, would I choose this person again?* Not "do I love them" — love survives almost anything, including arrangements that should end. Would you *choose* it, today, with current information, at current prices?

The question frightens people because they think asking it weakens the relationship. The opposite is true. A yes you never tested is not a yes; it's a habit wearing a yes's clothes. Most seasons, in a good love, the answer comes back fast and warm, and you walk out of the question more married than you walked in — because now the staying is fresh, paid for, yours. And if one season the answer hesitates, you want to know *that season*, while the displacement is still small and the conversation can still be cheap. Put a date on it. The calendar is where honesty goes to survive your moods.

Some couples can ask it out loud, together, once a year. That is a high-trust move and not where you start. Start alone.

Keep your own ground

The third return is the one lovers are talked out of: keep your own friends, your own work, your own practices — the run, the standing Thursday, the project with your name on it alone. Not as escape hatches. As maintenance of your S0 itself.

This does three jobs at once. It keeps your ground legible, so you can always measure your own displacement and notice drift early. It keeps C_return finite, so staying remains a choice and the door remains a door — which, as Module 2 argued, is what makes walking past it daily mean something. And it keeps you a person rather than a function, which is the thing your partner fell in love with in the first place. Two intact people choosing a shared state is a relationship. Two half-people fused at the missing parts is a splint.

Guard the other person's ground as fiercely as your own. When they protect their Thursday, that is not distance from you. That is them staying someone worth coming home to — and keeping their staying chosen, which is the only version of their staying worth having.

Practice

Schedule the returns this week, literally, in a calendar: ten undistracted minutes with your person daily, and one seasonal date — three months out — labeled with the question from this module. If

you're single, schedule the third return instead: one standing weekly visit to your own ground.

- Which of the three returns — daily presence, the seasonal question, your own ground — have you skipped longest?
- What do you currently do *instead* of the ten minutes, and what is it worth?
- Whose ground is better defended right now — yours or theirs?

Module 5: Leaving

A paid return

Sometimes the arithmetic comes back wrong and keeps coming back wrong. The distance was always too far, or the dissolution went too deep to rebuild in place, or you've revisited the choice honestly, season after season, and the yes will not come. The framework has one more thing to say, and it is not a failure clause. It is this: leaving is a return. Going back to your own ground is a legitimate move, with a price, like every other return in this course — C_return, paid in full, mostly in grief.

Calling it a return matters. The cynical frame says leaving is quitting; the sentimental frame says leaving is tragedy. Both frames hide the actual transaction: you are paying a large fixed cost once to stop paying a daily cost forever. Whether that trade is right is just the same arithmetic you've been running all along — except now you respect both sides of the ledger instead of pretending one of them is zero.

Grief is the cost, not the punishment

Expect the grief to be enormous, and expect it even when leaving is right. This is where people get confused: they treat the size of the grief as evidence — *if it hurts this much, I must have made a mistake*. No. Grief is C_return's largest line item. It scales with what was real, not with what was wrong. You can grieve hard for years over leaving a relationship that absolutely needed leaving, and both things stay true the whole time.

So pay it like a cost, not a verdict. It is front-loaded where the daily cost was endless; it is finite where the vigilance was not; and on the far side of it sits your own ground, which you kept legible — if you did the work of Module 4 — exactly so that there would be somewhere to return *to*.

Leaving well

If you leave, pay your own bill. The common dodge is to make the other person fund your exit: manufacturing contempt, cataloguing their flaws, escalating until they do something that makes leaving feel cheap and justified. People do this because grief priced honestly is expensive, and a villain brings the price down. But the discount is taken out of the other person's account — and out of the truth of what you had, which you will want intact later, when you're trying to understand your own history.

Leaving well means: the arithmetic spoken plainly, the entanglements unwound fairly, the story told without a monster in it. *The distance was too far. I paid daily for years. I am going home.* It will be the hardest honest thing you ever say, and it leaves both ledgers clean.

Against cynicism

If this module reads as permission to bolt, read it again. Nothing here argues for leaving. It argues for keeping leaving *thinkable* — because that is what makes staying real. A love you cannot leave is a wall. A love you could leave, and don't — today, again, eyes open, price known — is the entire point of this course. The framework is not here to talk you out of love. It is here so that when you stay, and in a good love you will stay thousands of times, every one of those days is a day you chose.

Practice

Write the leaving honestly — one page, whether or not you'd ever do it: what a return to your own ground would actually cost, item by item, grief included. Not to plan it. To make it thinkable. Then notice what you choose, now that it's a choice. If you've already left someone, write the page in past tense instead: what you paid, and what it bought.

- Which line item have you been most unwilling to look at?
- Does making leaving thinkable make you feel less committed — or more?
- If you stayed tomorrow as a choice instead of a default, what would you do differently by noon?

The Worksheet

Fill this in alone, fast, in pen. Speed beats polish — the first answer is usually the honest one. For each domain: your ground state (what you'd settle into if nothing were pulling), the actual shared state, the size of the gap, what holding the gap costs you on an ordinary day, what returning to your own ground in that domain would cost once, and a decision. Only three decisions are allowed: **keep** (the gap is fine, paid gladly), **renegotiate** (the gap is real and the shared state should move), or **return** (go back to your ground in this domain — which, note, usually does *not* mean leaving the relationship; it means reclaiming the Thursday, the friend, the work).

Domain	My S0 (my ground)	Our S*		D — daily cost (rested / managed / vigilant)	C_return (what going back would cost)	Decision (keep / renegotiate / return)
		(where we actually live)	xi (none / small / large)			
Home and space						
Sleep and body						
Food and the table						
Money						
Work and ambition						
Friends						
Family						
Sex and affection						

Domain	My S0 (my ground)	Our S* (where we actually live)	xi (none / small / large)	D — daily cost (rested / managed / vigilant)	C_return (what going back would cost)	Decision (keep / renegotiate / return)
Speech — what I can say out loud Time alone Meaning — faith, purpose, the big questions The future — place, children, old age						

Read it in two passes. First, read down the xi and D columns together: a large gap you barely feel is suspicious — check whether you’ve dissolved in that domain and lost the ground you’d measure from. A small gap that costs vigilance daily is also suspicious — the gap may be bigger than you’ve admitted. Second, read the Decision column as a whole. A column full of *keep* is a relationship in good repair. A few *renegotiates* is a relationship with maintenance due — normal, schedule the conversations. A column where *return* keeps appearing, domain after domain, is your ledger telling you something the rest of you has been declining to read. Don’t act on the table in a day. But don’t unread it, either.

Then date it, file it, and fill a fresh one next season. The single most informative thing this worksheet produces is not any one copy — it’s the difference between two copies.

The Path

A course ends; the arithmetic doesn’t. You now hold four quantities — your ground, your actual state, the daily cost of the gap, the price of return — and one theorem: scheduled returns beat accumulated drift. Everything else was application.

So the path is just the returns, kept: ten minutes of real presence a day. The seasonal question, asked honestly, alone, on a date the calendar enforces. Your own ground — friends, work, the standing Thursday — visited and defended, and theirs defended just as hard. The worksheet, once a season, in pen. The leaving, kept thinkable, precisely so the staying stays real.

None of this is romantic in the usual sense. All of it is what romance is made of, on the days when nobody is writing songs: two people, close grounds, a shared state cheap enough to rest in, a door that works, and the same quiet choice made again this morning.

That’s the whole secret, and it isn’t one. Love that lasts is just love with its maintenance done.